areas, nor across much of the southern part of the subcontinent. Nor did the subcontinental epithet Mleccha or barbarian, apply only to people outside, since it also applied to the ‘primitive tribes’ and other ‘impure’ beings who didn’t belong to any of the dominant religio-cultural streams within the subcontinent.

Yijing writes that the people of ‘the West’ do not call themselves ‘Hindu’, nor give ‘the West’ a single name, such as ‘India’. Only the tribes outside, in the far north and west, use the term ‘Hindu’ to refer to *all* the people—irrespective of their faith—on the other side of the river Sindhu (Sanskrit for Indus), a region that includes much of the subcontinent. Xuanzang expresses much the same view and refers to this vast expanse as *In-tu*,[17] which his nineteenth-century translator, Samuel Beal, renders as *India*. That Xuanzang uses a single word for ‘the land beyond the Sindhu’ suggests that he too sees something culturally distinctive about it; he even describes its salient features *as a whole*: its physical dimensions, measures of time and distance, social customs, languages, religions and more.

‘Hindu’, related to ‘Sindhu’, was then strictly an ethno-geographic descriptor, a term for those who resided in this region, and not the religious one that it would gradually become from the late medieval to the colonial era. (Western Indologists would also coin the term ‘Hinduism’, which included far more than just Brahminism.) In Yijing’s time (as also in Megasthenes’s and Alberuni’s time), outsiders saw even animists, polytheists, ancestor worshippers, Jains and Buddhists as ‘Hindu’. (For a rough analogy, consider how modern urban upper-class Indians might see rural India—as full of ‘peasants’ or ‘villagers’ in certain attires, though the latter may not use any unifying identities for themselves and see their different communities and lifeworlds as completely distinct.)

Traversing the Land

In terms of general prosperity, the Chinese pilgrims see India and China as mostly on par, as in the quality of buildings, clothing and food. As for people, Xuanzang calls Indians ‘upright and honourable’, ‘not deceitful or treacherous in their conduct’, and ‘faithful to their oaths and promises’. ‘They dread the retribution of another state of existence, and make light of